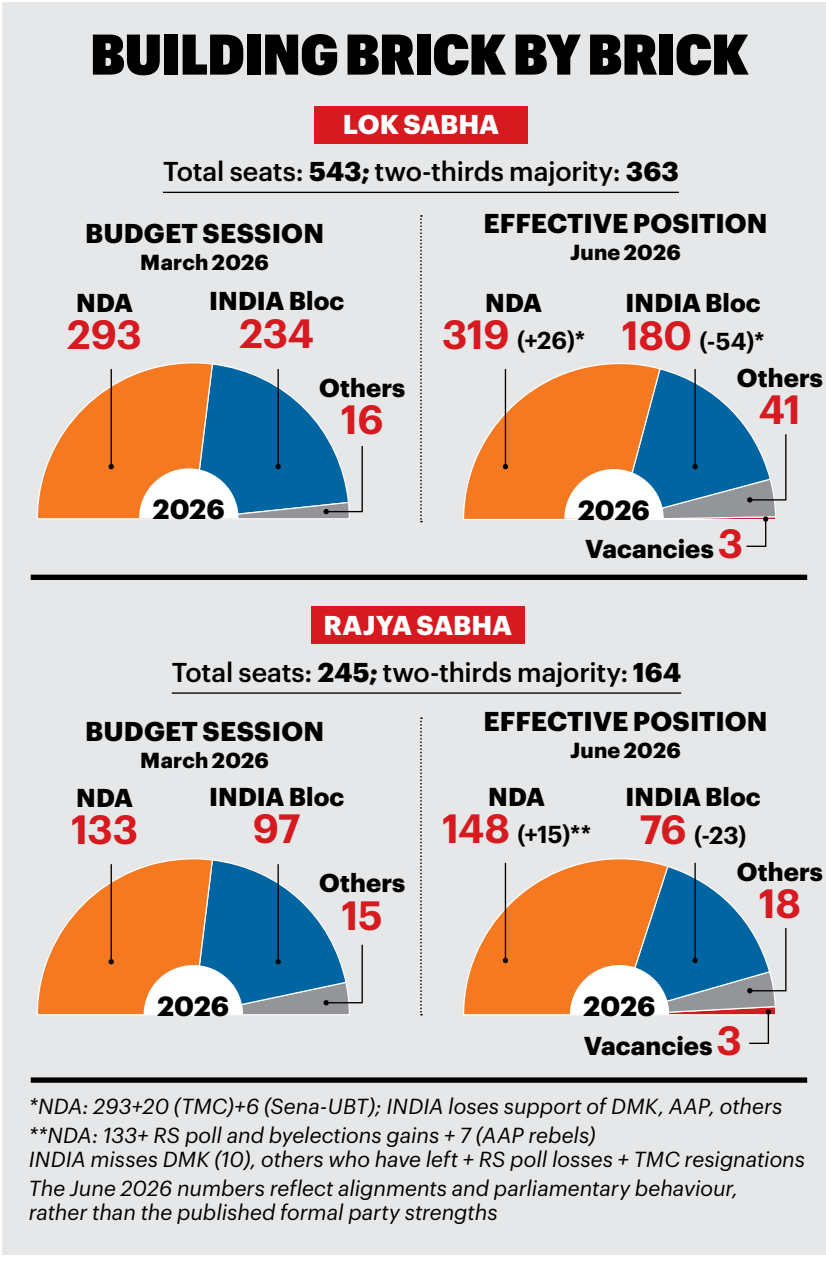


tying it to an expanded Lok Sabha, was defeated on the floor by 298 votes to 230, well short of the two-thirds mark (352 votes out of the 528 MPs present) the amendment needed. It was the first time an amendment had been blocked in Narendra Modi's tenure as prime minister. The defeat laid bare a central fact: the BJP does not have a majority of its own and depends on allies to clear the 272 mark; the NDA musters 293 and the Opposition INDIA bloc 232. On that day, a fractious Opposition discovered that it could hold the line when it chose to. The lesson the ruling side took from it is that the math that cannot be altered at the ballot box can still be altered in between elections. The months since have been an exercise in doing exactly that.

The shift began with the smallest numbers. The recent Rajya Sabha election round in May-June covered 26 seats, 24 of them biennial and two bypolls, and the BJP-led NDA took 21 of those seats (a gain of six seats). Four came from Andhra Pradesh, with three moving from the YSR Congress (YSRCP) to the ruling Telugu Desam Party-led alliance. That was the latest in a collapse that had cut Jagan Reddy's party from 151 assembly seats in 2019 to 11 in 2024, and from 22 Lok Sabha seats to four. Madhya Pradesh produced a sharper episode. The returning officer rejected the nomination papers of the lone Congress candidate, Meenakshi Natarajan, on technical grounds, turning a likely two-to-one split into a clean sweep of three BJP members elected unopposed (see *Nomination Shock* in Statescan). The Rajya Sabha has 245 seats with 123 the majority mark. The NDA now commands about 148 seats—16 short of a two-thirds majority—with the BJP the largest single block at 114.

A THOUSAND CUTS

What was a trickle in the Upper House has become a flood in the Lower House, and its trigger was the ballot box. The BJP captured West Bengal for the first time in May, taking 207 of the 294 assembly seats and reducing Mamata Banerjee's TMC to just 80 seats. Of late, regional parties that lose their home state seem to lose the thing that keeps ambitious legislators in line—the expectation of reward—and the parliamentary aftershock was quick. On June 14, 19 TMC Lok Sabha MPs met speaker Om Birla, with a 20th, Rachana Banerjee, sending her consent from abroad, to tell him they were merging with the Nationalist Citizens Party of India (NCPI), an obscure Tripura-based outfit with no prior presence in Parliament, and that they would support the NDA. Twenty of the party's 28 Lok Sabha members clears the two-thirds criteria of the anti-defection law required for a merger. If Birla recognises the NCPI, it will overnight become the second-largest NDA contingent in the Lok Sabha, ahead of the TDP's 16.

The Upper House was bleeding at the same time. In a single week, three TMC members from West Bengal resigned—Sukhendu Sekhar Ray, Sushmita Dev and Prakash Chik Baraik.